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California Lawmakers Advance Vital Chemical Safety, Food Reforms EWG Supports

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WASHINGTON, May 24 -- The Environmental Working Group issued the following news release:

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California lawmakers advance vital chemical safety, food reforms EWG supports

SACRAMENTO - In a major win for public health, five bills targeting harmful ultra-processed food and hazardous chemicals in drinking water and specific products cleared the California Assembly and Senate appropriations committees today.

They include a bill that, if enacted, would make California the first state to adopt new standards for ultra-processed foods, as well as a bill that would require consumer disclosures for prenatal vitamins.

Another bill would set strong water standards for the "forever chemicals" known as PFAS, amid threat of a rollback of Environmental Protection Agency PFAS water limits. Finally, two other bills that would limit toxic chemicals in food packaging and other products also passed this important milestone.

The Environmental Working Group is a co-sponsor of all these bills.

"From classrooms to kitchen tables, California is taking concrete steps to reduce everyday exposures to toxic chemicals and protect public health and the environment," said Bernadette Del Chiaro, EWG's senior vice president for California.

"These bills reflect growing momentum in California to close dangerous loopholes in chemical safety," continued Del Chiaro. "Lawmakers are standing up for parents, children and vulnerable communities by moving forward commonsense protections that should have been in place long ago."

Assembly bills

The Assembly Appropriations Committee approved three EWG-backed bills, advancing them to the full Assembly.

AB 794, by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino), would mandate new state drinking water standards to protect Californians from exposure to PFAS, which has been linked to serious health harms, including cancer, cardiovascular diseases, reproductive harm and developmental issues in infants and children. Recent tests suggest that nearly 19 million Californians have tap water with PFAS contamination.

"With almost 19 million Californians exposed to PFAS from their tap, California cannot afford to rely on federal action," said Del Chiaro. "Especially given the threat of backsliding by the EPA on PFAS, California must take bold action now to set its own drinking water limits for these toxic forever chemicals."

AB 1148, authored by Assemblymember LaShae Sharp-Collins, Ed.D. (D-San Diego), would restrict the manufacture, distribution and sale of food packaging containing two concerning additives.

AB 1264, authored by Gabriel, is a first-in-the-nation bill that would phase out certain "particularly harmful" ultra-processed foods, or UPF, out of meals served in public schools. If signed into law, it would also establish a first-in-the-nation legal definition for UPF.

"Processed foods can have a place in a healthy diet, but Americans - especially children - consume too many ultra-processed foods, which is contributing to increased rates of cancer, heart disease and behavioral issues in children and diabetes," said Del Chiaro.

"AB 1264 takes an important step toward protecting children's health by identifying and removing the most harmful ultra-processed foods from California public schools," she added. "We commend Assemblymember Gabriel and all of the bill's co-authors for taking commonsense steps toward better protecting the well-being of California's children."

Senate bills

The Senate Appropriations Committee also considered and approved two EWG-sponsored bills, moving them along for consideration by the full Senate in the next two weeks.

SB 646, authored by Senator Dr. Akilah Weber Pierson (D-San Diego) would require prenatal vitamin manufacturers to test for and publicly disclose levels of potentially harmful heavy metals in their products.

If the bill is signed into law, California would set a precedent for stronger maternal health protections nationwide. The measure would require manufacturers to regularly test a representative sample of their products and post results online, beginning in 2027.

"Expecting mothers deserve transparency about the ingredients in the supplements they take to support their health and their baby's growth," said Susan Little, EWG legislative director for California. "It's alarming to find heavy metals in prenatal vitamins. This bill is a critical step toward giving consumers the facts and pushing companies to make safer products."

SB 682, authored by Sen. Ben Allen (D-Santa Monica), would prohibit the sale or distribution of nearly all products containing intentionally added PFAS, on a schedule from 2027 to 2040. The bill would also create a regulatory program to enforce and carry out the bill's prohibitions.

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The Environmental Working Group (EWG) is a nonprofit, non-partisan organization that empowers people to live healthier lives in a healthier environment. Through research, advocacy and unique education tools, EWG drives consumer choice and civic action.

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